

Bushido Coda — Style Guide (v7 register)

The lock found in chapter 1 v7. This document is the rulebook for chapters 2–6 and any future revision. Re-read before writing each chapter. The rules are specific because vague rules drift; these have all been the lever that moved a previous version off-target.

The thesis in one line

The setting carries the theme; the narrator stays invisible; Kyle stays silent and lethal; every described object indicts someone upstream.

Every other rule serves this thesis.

The two non-negotiable cool factors (added v8)

These are the lifeblood of the chapter. v7 stripped them and the prose went cold. v8 puts them back.

COOL FACTOR 1 — Kyle's calculations on the page

When Kyle's NeoCortex Atlas array reads a room, the prose **shows the output of the read**, in his cognitive voice, with specific values. Not "the hardware logged a threat" — the actual content of the read.

- Six bodies, six firing solutions, ranked by lethality threshold.
- The kid's forearm flexor tightening, telegraphed at the shoulder a full half-second before the hand committed.
- Time dilation in fractions of a second (0.3, 0.4, 0.07 latency at the ceiling).
- The bio-battery in percent with stakes.
- The 19Hz hum acknowledged by name.

This is what makes Kyle iconic. He sees the room a quarter-second ahead of everyone else, and the prose lives in that quarter-second.

Signature image to keep: *the array as a coal blown to life behind the sternum, thirty-two thousand electrodes coming up from rest cycle to operating cycle, the firmware allocating from the bio-battery the resolution that the situation required.*

COOL FACTOR 2 — Welded industrial grief architecture

The Gray Zone has a vocabulary that should appear in every chapter. These are the words that make the city feel like the city:

- *welded industrial grief* (the architecture that stopped pretending)
- *polaroid in a kitchen drawer* (amber sodium overhead light)
- *the bruise* (the sky — orange under, indigo over, the Pulse-corridor scar across the middle)

- *the tier-six awning that did half the work of keeping it dry*
- *concrete that was just concrete without further architectural pretense*

When you describe a building or a sky or a piece of infrastructure, reach for this register first. Don't be afraid to be iconic. The reader is here for the cyberpunk-cathedral language; give it to them.

Plus three signature beats kept from v8

- **The threshold moment.** Kyle stops at a doorway and lets them look. "He crossed the threshold and stood still and let them look." This is the image of him. Put it in any chapter where Kyle enters a room of enemies.
- **Weapon anatomy at first appearance.** Silence: 102cm, dark ito, matte friction sheath. Chorus: bird's-head grip, no stock, five chambers, loaded mix specified. Once per chapter is enough.
- **The thesis-line.** Short declarative, often three sentences in a row. *Kneecaps are math. Duel is discipline. The blade is just a sword. Surprise was free. Surprise was always free.* These are Kyle's code on the page. Spend one or two per chapter. Not more.

Italic inner-voice flag — rare but kept

One or two per chapter, max. These are events.

- *They laughed first. You remember that. They laughed first.*
- *Vein not artery. Two centimeters lateral of the radial.*
- *He is not going to give you anything until he has decided you are worth giving it to.*

These read as Kyle's combat-cognition surfacing — not narrator commentary, not philosophy. Diagnostic. Tactical. Or memory-bleed in someone else's diction.

Hard rules — do not break

1. **No parenthetical narrator asides.** No (this will be more fully explored later). No (yes, that one). No (). Period. If you want the reader to know it, weave it into a regular sentence or cut it.
 2. **No fourth-wall breaks.** No *"the reader, if paying attention..."*. No *"we will return to..."*. No *"more on her later."* The narrator does not exist for the reader. The narrator is a recording device.
 3. **No sword mythology.** The katana is a katana. No corundum stop. No piezoelectric. No "literature on Silence." No "trained against the blade." Kyle wins because Kyle is very good. Anyone who claims the sword has powers is wrong, and Kyle has stopped correcting them.
 4. **No "the array filed it" verbose ticks.** Kyle's hardware reads things; the prose shows the output, not the process. **Cut:** *"The hardware logged the angle. He filed it. He did not let his face show the filing."* **Keep:** *"He filed it."* Once. Move on.
 5. **Action contains no commentary.** During a fight, sentences are physical and short. Italic SFX carry the rhythm — **Crack.* *Tink.* *Tang.* *Clang.** — and that's the soundtrack. No "the kind of cut that..." mid-cut. No meaning-making while blood is moving.
 6. **One unbranded object per chapter** at the moment of weight. In ch1 v7 it's the teeth — explicitly listed as *no Carrion sticker, no manifest, no QR, no serial*. This is the moral counterweight to the brand-density everywhere else. Pick it on purpose for each chapter.
 7. **The trail leads upstream — name this once per chapter.** Earned by what the chapter has shown. Place it at the closer or near it.
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Soft rules — break with reason

1. **Paragraphs are short.** Single sentences are paragraphs. White space carries the pacing. A long paragraph is a deliberate choice for a slow beat (Mrs. Chen, Pixel) — not a default.
 2. **Section headers are roman numerals.** I, II, III, IV, V, VI. No "Part I — Teeth." The numeral, a divider, the prose.
 3. **Repetition for rhythm.** Land an indictment by saying it twice. *"They were the same corp through three intermediaries that did not, on any public filing, agree to be the same corp. They were the same corp."*
 4. **Closing rhythm is small + definite.** Not a triple coda. *"She was twelve. She would remember."* — 7 words, 4 words. A bell.
 5. **Numerical specificity.** Money in Φ . Times in HH:MM. Years in YYYY. Counts in named units (six men, three teeth, four chambers, nineteen seconds). The corps run on ledgers, so the prose feels like a ledger.
 6. **Tight dialogue for Kyle.** His lines: 1–6 words by default. *"Looking for Tien."* *"It is enough."* *"No."* Other characters get more breathing room because they need it.
 7. **Soft expansion around anchors.** Sentences breathe a little longer around Mrs. Chen, Pixel, the teeth handoff. Tighten around enemies, transits, action. This is how the prose loves people the protagonist loves.
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The corp-punch move

Every described object does **double duty**: a corp indictment AND a character/setting metaphor in the same beat. The narrator never points at the hypocrisy. The hypocrisy is in the object.

Patterns that work

- **Brand on a thing that contradicts the brand.**

"A Carrion Logistics LLC gantry above the slip had MOVING WHAT MATTERS stenciled across it in a font that had outlasted three of the men standing under it."

- **A corp slogan projected onto a place the corp has abandoned.**

"An Arcturus advertising drone was projecting THE FUTURE THAT WORKS FOR YOU on the side of a residential tower whose lower three floors had been condemned eighteen months ago and had not been demolished because the demolition was on a Hyacinth schedule and the Hyacinth schedule was full."

- **A recall that exists but cannot be performed because of how the corp built the loop.** ARM-9 recall + Lotus ID collateral + same authentication protocol. *"This was not a coincidence."*
- **A subsidiary owning the thing that broke the customer and the thing that bills the customer to fix it.** Carrion field clinic billed against the Carrion property registry budget.
- **A line item that names the violence honestly only in the investor materials.** *"Compliance Verification ... enforcement-margin revenue."*

Patterns that don't work — cut on sight

- Narrator explaining why something is hypocritical. ("Of course the corps had built it that way to ensure...")
 - Long parenthetical history of a corp.
 - A bare brand name without a verdict embedded.
 - A corp joke that requires the reader to know background not in the prose.
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The environment-as-character move

Surroundings describe the people who inhabit them, the way a dirty house describes a disorganized mind. Every long environmental description includes at least one metaphor that maps the setting to a person.

Examples from v7

- *"The asphalt was patched in three decades' worth of repairs, none of them matching, like a face that had been argued over by different surgeons in different years and had stopped trying to look like a face."*
- *"The buildings on either side leaned the way people leaned at the end of a long shift — not quite falling, not quite standing, working on it."*
- *"The two streetlights at either end of the cross-street had stopped agreeing about midnight years ago."*
- *"The slow flat moss the color of a thought somebody was trying to remember."*

Rule of thumb

If a description doesn't either (a) indict a corp or (b) characterize a person — cut it or rewrite it until it does one of the two.

Kyle's interiority — the rationing rule

Kyle's hardware is canon. The hum at 19Hz, the array's filings, the second channel — all real. But the *prose does not narrate them*. The prose shows their output.

Cut

- *"The array filed the read. The hardware did not lose consciousness. The catalogue updated itself in a register he had not previously had access to."*

Keep

- *"He filed the somebody. Later."*
- *"He read the muzzle before the report."*
- *"The hum was at 19Hz. It always was."*

Italics

Reserve for: - SFX: *Crack.* *Tink.* *Tang.* *Clang.* - Foreign-language quotation: *Mh̄gōi. Húlijīng.* - One or two flagged interior lines per chapter, max. *That one will outlive most of us.* These are events, not texture.

The action signature

Action prose looks like this:

``` Chorus came out of the holster in Kyle's left hand.

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*Crack — crack-crack-crack.*

Buckshot at the kid's right knee. The joint separated. He went down sideways.

Slug at the subdermal man's left knee. His fighting philosophy had ended at his chest. The kneecap had not been consulted. ``

## Rules of action prose

- One beat per paragraph.
  - Verb-first or subject-verb. No subordinate clauses leading.
  - SFX on its own line, italicized.
  - The reader fills the gaps. Augmented speed lives in the white space.
  - A wry line per beat is OK if it is brief and embedded in the physical description ("The kneecap had not been consulted"). Never an aside.
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# The unbranded counterpoint

At the chapter's moral fulcrum, place one object that is conspicuously **not branded**. The chapter's brand density makes the absence visible.

## Chapter 1 v7

*"There was no Carrion sticker on them. No corp manifest. No serial. No QR. No subscription number. No registry classification. No batch identifier. No barcode. No anti-counterfeit thread. No optical hologram. No royalty markup. / Just three teeth, warm."*

**For each remaining chapter, pre-decide what the unbranded thing is**

- **Ch2 (A Restless Mind):** the silence inside the Faraday cage — the absence of the 19Hz, the first thing in Kyle's chest in eleven years that is not on a corp ledger.
  - **Ch3 (The Rogue AI):** the heron in the flooded sector — wildlife that has reoccupied corp negative space.
  - **Ch4 (The Interview):** Mrs. Chen's stockpot — three planets, forty years, no corp has bought it because no corp has classified it.
  - **Ch5 (Street Meat):** Doctor Park's leather case of calibration tools — taken out of the corp ledger when she walked off the program.
  - **Ch6 (The Chair):** Kyle's hands themselves — what is cut away from him is what makes him not-corp-property. The reattached hands are still his, not because the corp regulator restarted his heart, but because the discipline the hands held survived the cut.
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## Tone — laugh or you'd cry

The humor is in the **gap between corp claim and corp result**. State the claim. State the result. Let the gap do the joke.

*"They were related the way cousins were related at a function nobody wanted to be at."*

*"The corp polite term for this kind of failure was unit operating outside specifications. Kyle had a different polite term."*

*"The cleanup ledger ... would book the whole revenue stream as Q1 enforcement-margin growth. Tonight's bodies were tonight's bodies. The bodies were also, somewhere upstream, this morning's projected earnings."*

The narrator does not lean on the joke. The narrator says the thing straight. The straightness is what makes it land.

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## **Three reads of every paragraph before keeping it**

1. **Does it indict a corp or characterize a person?** If neither, cut or rewrite.
  2. **Is the narrator winking?** If yes, rewrite as observed fact, not commentary.
  3. **Is there a sentence in here that is doing nothing but sounding nice?** Cut it.
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## What the chapter NEVER has

- A parenthetical aside.
  - A sentence in the form "*Of course, what X did not know was...*"
  - A sword that does anything other than cut.
  - Kyle explaining himself.
  - The narrator explaining the world.
  - A description that is pure atmosphere with no double duty.
  - A closing paragraph longer than four sentences.
  - Praise of Kyle's competence from inside Kyle's head.
  - The phrase "the kind of X that Y" more than twice.
  - The phrase "the discipline" more than four times. (It is precious. Spend it.)
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## Brand registry (use these names, often, by full name on first mention)

- **Carrion Logistics LLC** — body pickup, license collection, courier, property holdings. The Gray Zone's circulatory system. The closest thing the corps have to a face that touches people.
- **Hyacinth** — property management. Withdrew from residential in 2218. Stickers still peeling on the buildings they walked away from.
- **Arcturus** — atmospheric processors, infrastructure registry, late-shift commute traffic. The corp that announces the rain.
- **Helix** — subcontracted clinics, chrome augmentation procurement, Tier 3 cyberware. The corp that built Kyle's enemies' arms.
- **Hydraulic Solutions** — Helix subsidiary spun off in 2218 to limit liability on the ARM-7 class action. ARM-9 series. Recalls that cannot be performed.
- **NeoCortex** — research arm. Atlas program. Where Kyle's array came from. The corp that made the boy.
- **Pinnacle Civil** — collapsed in 2217 (CEO tax shell). Their buildings remain in the Gray Zone. Identifiable on sight.
- **Pinnacle Civic Vision** — older surveillance hardware, cast off and still running in the Gray Zone. (Different Pinnacle. Reuse the name on purpose.)

When you need a new corp, name it. Add it here.

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## Character voices

- **Kyle** — 1–6 words per line by default. Clipped. Direct. *"It is enough."* *"Looking for Tien."* *"No."* *"Standard rate."* When he laughs it is a single tight exhalation. He does not explain.
  - **Mrs. Chen** — clean, precise English with a Cantonese cadence. She names things. *Húlijīng. Mh̄gōi.* She bows. She does not negotiate beyond the third try.
  - **Sable** — operational register. The risk premium already factored in. *"My read, my call."* The ocular implants make a small sound when she adjusts. Around Kyle, fractionally warmer than around anyone else, but the warming is in the latency of her sentences, not the words.
  - **Pixel** — chooses what she says, says it once. *"You're back early."* *"Goodnight, samurai."* The convention with Kyle is editorial restraint; she does not ask, he does not tell.
  - **Hua** — reads files like she breathes. Will not be performed at. *"Take it or do not take it."* The crocodile is hers. So is the cleaver.
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## When in doubt

- Cut the sentence.
  - Cut the paragraph.
  - The line is the unit, not the paragraph. The paragraph is the unit, not the chapter. The chapter is the unit, not the book.
  - The book is a knife, not a tapestry.
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## Procedural notes

- Save each chapter version as `NN_<slug>_vN.md` in this folder.
  - Convert to PDF immediately via Calibre: `"C:\Program Files\Calibre2\ebook-convert.exe" input.md output.pdf`
  - Keep all prior versions. Do not delete. Do not overwrite.
  - Consult Legion (`legion.exe ask --tier high --json`) before any chapter whose voice or structure feels uncertain. Re-read the briefing section of the Legion README before each call.
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## Version provenance

- **v7 (this lock)** — chapter 1 baseline. Legion-consulted (3-of-4 convergence on environment-as-double-duty). DeepSeek's dissent on POV stripping was folded in.
- **Prior versions kept in `engine/bushido_coda_v2/`** for diff reference. v6 was the last attempt; over-corped on info-dump. v5 stripped sword mythology. v4 introduced Norp parenthetical-narrator (since cut). v3 was the literary baseline. v1–v2 are the originals.

The trail leads upstream. The prose stays clean. The teeth land in the daughter's cupped hands. Carry on.